

Anal Itching

(Pruritus Ani)

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Itching of the anus (the opening at the end of the digestive tract where stool leaves the body) and the skin around the anus (perianal skin) is called anal itching or pruritus ani.

(See also [Overview of the Anus and Rectum](#).)

Causes of Anal Itching

The **most common** causes of anal itching are

- Unknown (the majority)
- Related to hygiene

Most often, doctors do not identify a specific disorder as the cause of anal itching, and the itching goes away without treatment after a period of time. Many of the other cases of anal itching are due to hygiene issues. Only a very few cases are caused by a specific disorder (see table [Causes and Features of Anal Itching](#)), such as [pinworms](#) or a fungal infection (such as candidiasis caused by several species of the yeast *Candida*). Of the specific causes, only rare causes such as [inflammatory bowel disease](#) and cancer of the skin around the anus are considered serious.

Extremes in hygiene can lead to anal itching. For instance, inadequate cleansing leaves irritating stool and sweat residue on the anal skin. More commonly, overly vigorous cleansing, often with sanitary wipes and strong soaps, can dry or irritate the skin or occasionally cause an allergic reaction. [Hemorrhoids](#) can make it difficult for people to thoroughly clean themselves after a bowel movement. Some hemorrhoids produce mucus or cause leakage, both of which can cause itching.

Young children and older adults may have problems controlling their urine (called [urinary incontinence](#)) or stool (called [stool incontinence](#) in children and [fecal incontinence](#) in adults). These disorders may cause irritation that leads to skin infections and anal itching.

Once anal itching starts, an itch-scratch-itch cycle can begin, in which scratching causes more itching. Often, people scratch and rub the itchy area so much that they scrape the skin open. The scrapes sometimes become irritated, which causes yet more itching. Also, people sometimes become allergic to the ointments or other treatments they use for the itching.

Evaluation of Anal Itching

Not every episode of anal itching requires immediate evaluation by a doctor. The following information can help people decide whether a doctor's evaluation is needed and help them know what to expect during the evaluation.

Warning signs

In people with anal itching, certain symptoms and characteristics are cause for concern. They include

- Pus draining from the anus or around it (draining fistula)
- Bloody diarrhea
- Bulging or protruding hemorrhoids
- Perianal skin soiled with fecal material
- Dull or thickened perianal skin

When to see a doctor

People who have anal itching plus bloody diarrhea or draining pus should see a doctor as soon as possible.

Other people should see a doctor if the itching has lasted for more than a few days, but the visit is not urgent.

What the doctor does

Doctors first ask questions about the person's symptoms and medical history. Doctors then do a physical examination. What they find during the history and physical

examination often suggests a cause of the itching and the tests that may need to be done (see table [Causes and Features of Anal Itching](#)).

The history is focused on when the itching started and how long it has lasted. Doctors ask about the following:

- Ingestion of irritating foods, particularly acidic or spicy foods
- Bowel habits, including use of wipes, ointments (even those used to treat itching), sprays, and soaps applied to the anus
- Hygiene habits, particularly frequency of showers and baths
- Known infections or disorders (such as diabetes, hemorrhoids, or psoriasis)
- Recent use of antibiotics

The physical examination is focused on the appearance of the anus and the perianal skin. Doctors examine this area for

- Dullness and thickness
- Signs of irritation due to scratching
- [Hemorrhoids](#), lesions, fistulas, and scrapes (caused by scratching and rubbing)
- [Scabies](#) or [pinworms](#)



Causes and Features of Anal Itching

Cause	Common Features*	Tests
Anal or rectal disorders		
<u>Inflammatory bowel disease</u> (such as <u>Crohn disease</u>)	Discharge of pus Pain in the rectum (sometimes) and/or abdomen (often) Sometimes diarrhea	Examination of the lower portion of the large intestine, the rectum, and the anus with an endoscope (sigmoidoscopy) or of the entire large intestine (colonoscopy)
<u>Hemorrhoids</u> (internal or external)	With internal hemorrhoids, bleeding (a small amount of blood on toilet paper or in the toilet bowl) With external hemorrhoids, a painful, swollen lump on the anus	A doctor's examination Usually examination of the rectum with an endoscope (anoscopy) or sigmoidoscopy
Infections		
<u>Bacterial infection</u> (caused by scratching)	Inflamed, red area, sometimes visible scratches	A doctor's examination
 MSD <u>Fungal infection</u> (eg, candidiasis [yeast infection])	A rash around the anus	A doctor's examination Sometimes examination of a sample of skin scrapings under a microscope (to identify the fungus)
<u>Pinworms</u>	Usually in children	Microscopic examination of